entrance off Red Road is a striking War Memorial where, as customary, I laid a wreath after the Guard of Honour, before proceeding to the Main Office building. The Main Office was in an imposing five-storeyed building, which had been under construction for some time. In fact, during my earlier tenure as IGAR(N), the building was still under construction, so it was my first visit to this new complex. After getting to know the officers, including the Chief of Staff, Lt Gen Srivastava of the Artillery, over a cup of tea, it was time to get down to business.

Each Command is unique in its own way and has its own challenges, and Eastcom was no different. The jurisdiction of the command spans nine states with borders with five countries, including the Tibet region of China. The operational AOR extends from the tri-junction between Nepal–Tibet–India in the West to Tibet–India–Myanmar in the East, and then Southwards all along the 1643-km-long Indo–Myanmar border. The border with Bangladesh is the responsibility of the BSF. Sikkim was with 33 Corps, Western Arunachal Pradesh with 4 Corps and Eastern Arunachal with 3 Corps. The Myanmar border adjoining our states of Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur and Mizoram was manned by the Assam Rifles. This arrangement was as per the government's policy of 'one border—one force'. Thus, the International Border was with the BSF, the LC and LAC with the Army, Tibet (China) with the ITBP, Nepal with the SSB and Myanmar with the AR. In practice though, it was the Army only that was manning the Tibet border, even though the ITBP was co-located. In most places, it was the Army outpost that was in front, especially in the sensitive and disputed areas.

In the evening was the official 'dining-in' party. Just as we were about to leave for the Command Mess, there was an urgent call from the COS and I wondered what flap had happened on

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